

Workstation Owner Guide

Keep this copy on the laptop

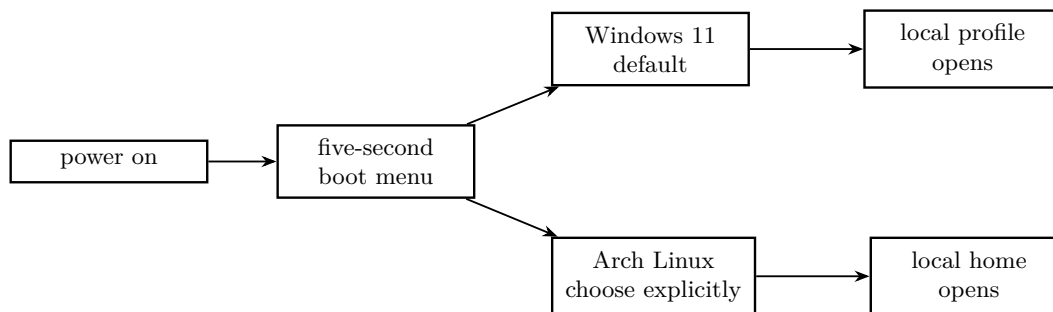
Normal use, automatic updates, recovery, and useful evidence

This is the first-stop guide for someone using a Telos dual-boot workstation away from home. It covers ordinary use and safe, reversible recovery. It contains no household names, addresses, credentials, recovery keys, or administrator-only procedure.

THE SAFE BOUNDARY

You may restart, choose either operating system, reconnect Wi-Fi, check update status, free your own ordinary storage, test optional storage, and collect the evidence listed here. Stop before changing firmware, partitions, boot entries, directory membership, system time by hand, package databases, security policy, or another person's files.

Know the normal state



Windows starts if nobody touches the menu. Select Arch before the countdown ends when you need it. Your files live on the laptop, so login must work without home Wi-Fi, the Controller, or optional network storage.

Do: Sign in once while connected, disconnect Wi-Fi, lock, and sign in again.

Check: The same account opens the same local profile without a network error. Repeat once in each operating system before a long trip.

Do: Save work and sign out. Shut down before packing the laptop.

Check: No update screen, activity light, or warm fan remains when it enters the bag.

OFFLINE LOGIN HAS A LIMIT

A previously used account may continue to open this laptop while disconnected, even after an administrator disables its network access. This protects travel use but is not remote erasure. Report a lost laptop promptly.

Connect to Wi-Fi

Use the managed-workstation network supplied with the laptop. Its credential may be unique to this machine. Do not copy it to phones, televisions, guests, or another laptop.

1. Turn Wi-Fi off, wait five seconds, and turn it on.
2. Select the saved managed-workstation network.
3. Open one ordinary HTTPS site.
4. Check that the clock and time zone are correct automatically.
5. At home, sign out and in once to prove directory contact.

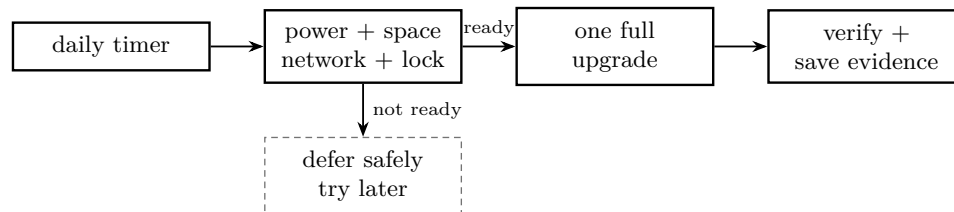
Expect: Internet access works. Management pages, peer devices, and unrelated household networks may remain unreachable by design.

If not: If the network is absent, test one other known network or a phone hotspot. If other networks work, record “managed network absent.” If none work, restart once and collect the Wi-Fi evidence on page 3. Do not forget and recreate the saved network unless an administrator asks.

Automatic updates

Windows: leave Windows Update enabled. Windows downloads and installs security and quality updates automatically, then asks for or schedules a restart. Plug in overnight at least weekly. Never use an advertised third-party “driver updater.”

Arch: a daily system timer attempts one complete `pacman -Syu` transaction. It runs only on AC power, with at least 8 GiB free, no other package transaction, and the official mirror reachable. A missed run is retried after the next boot. It records before/after package lists and verifies installed package files. It never interrupts a user session for a reboot.



Do: Plug in, connect to the internet, and leave the laptop awake for an hour each week. **Check:** Windows shows no pending security update. On Arch, `systemctl status homelab-arch-update.timer` says `active (waiting)` and shows a next run.

Do: Restart after an update requests it, or when Arch reports a reboot recommendation. Reopen your work first. **Check:** The selected OS boots, Wi-Fi reconnects, the clock is correct, and login succeeds.

NEVER PARTIALLY UPDATE ARCH

Do not run `pacman -Sy`, force package replacement, delete the pacman lock, change mirrors during a transaction, or power off while packages are being installed. Arch is maintained by full-system upgrades.

Optional network storage

Optional storage is a convenience, not your home directory. It appears after login as a mapped drive in Windows or a mounted folder under your Arch home. Login must succeed when storage is absent.

What you see	Likely meaning	Safe response
Drive/folder opens	Network and authorization work	Use normally
Storage unavailable	Away, server down, or route blocked	Work locally; retry later
Access denied	Server reachable; identity or permission differs	Record the exact message; do not alter permissions
Login itself fails	Not an acceptable storage failure	Disconnect Wi-Fi, test cached login, escalate

Do: Before travel, disconnect from the home network and open ordinary local documents. **Check:** The desktop and local files open promptly; the optional share may show unavailable without delaying login.

Do: Copy important work to its intended backup location when available. **Check:** Open the copied file from the destination. A visible name alone does not prove the bytes arrived.

Recovery ladder

Use this order. Stop as soon as normal operation returns; do not stack unrelated fixes.

1. **Protect the work.** Save open files locally. Photograph the exact message if saving is impossible.
2. **Check simple state.** Connect power. Check airplane mode, Wi-Fi, free storage, date, time zone, and Caps Lock.
3. **Retry once.** Repeat the failed action and note any change.
4. **Restart normally.** Use Restart, not a forced power-off.

5. **Try the other OS.** This separates hardware or firmware trouble from one operating system.
6. **Try offline login.** Disconnect Wi-Fi and use an account that has previously signed in on this machine.
7. **Use local rescue only when directed.** It regains local access; it does not administer the directory. Never send its password.
8. **Escalate with evidence.** Stop before firmware, boot, disk, identity, or security changes.

Symptom	One safe test	Stop boundary
No power	Known-good outlet and charger; hold power once	Burning smell, swelling, liquid, unusual heat
No boot menu	Remove docks and USB devices; power on once	Firmware settings or boot-entry editing
One OS fails	Boot the other OS; record the failing stage	Repair media, partition, or bootloader commands
Password rejected	Check layout/Caps Lock; test offline once	Repeated guesses, account tools, clock edits
No internet	Test another known network	Network reset or driver replacement
Disk nearly full	Review your trash/downloads	System paths, another user's files, partitions
Update failed	Leave power/network connected; record status	Forced package removal, lock deletion, firmware update

IMMEDIATE STOP

Power down, unplug, and seek help for a swollen battery, liquid ingress, smoke, burning odor, crackling, repeated thermal shutdown, exposed conductors, or a charger/port too hot to touch. Never recharge a visibly damaged battery.

Collect useful evidence without secrets

Create a plain-text note named with the date and machine label. Include:

- OS, whether it reached the desktop, and whether power was connected;
- local date/time shown and approximate location;
- what you attempted, exact result, and whether it worked before;
- exact error text or a photo cropped to the relevant window;
- last successful boot, login, and update;
- whether restart, the other OS, offline login, and another network worked;
- Windows Update history or these read-only Arch results:

```
systemctl status homelab-arch-update.timer --no-pager
systemctl status homelab-arch-update.service --no-pager
journalctl -u homelab-arch-update.service -b --no-pager
df -h /
```

Expect: The commands report timer state, the most recent update attempt, and free space. They do not change the machine.

Remove before sharing: passwords; Wi-Fi keys or QR codes; recovery keys; tokens; private keys; browser contents; personal documents; full addresses; public IP addresses; serial numbers; and another person's name or files. Send the bundle only through the family's agreed private channel. Never paste it into a public issue or chat.

Answer before continuing: Can another person reproduce the symptom from this note? Does it say what succeeded as well as what failed? Did you open every file and image to confirm no secret or unrelated personal material is visible?

When to ask for help

Ask soon: update failure persists through the next powered, internet-connected attempt; free space stays below 8 GiB; time repeatedly drifts; optional storage says access denied; either OS stops booting; or login works only offline.

Ask immediately: possible hardware damage; both operating systems fail; the disk disappears; a recovery key is unexpectedly requested; an unknown administrator prompt appears; the laptop is lost or stolen; or you suspect account compromise.

Administrator work only: directory accounts and revocation, domain rejoin, rescue-account rotation, firmware and Secure Boot, disk layout, encryption, boot entries, PXE, network policy, update policy, package repair, and storage authorization.

Keep this guide available offline

Every workstation image should install this versioned PDF at `/usr/local/share/doc/telos/workstation-owner-guide.pdf` on Arch and in the shared Telos documentation folder on Windows, with a desktop or Start-menu shortcut. The public web copy is convenient but is not the recovery copy.

Controller convergence distributes a newer reviewed guide by version; it never requires reinstalling the workstation. Deployment copies a new file, verifies its SHA-256 digest, then replaces the shortcut atomically. Keep the previous copy until the new PDF opens locally.

- Do:** Disconnect every network and open the shortcut in each operating system.
- Check:** The title is “Workstation Owner Guide,” footer version is 20260727.001, all pages render, and the recovery ladder needs no link.
- Do:** After an update, compare its version with the published manifest.
- Check:** The new digest matches and the previous readable copy remains until acceptance is complete.

BEFORE LEAVING HOME

Boot both operating systems, complete automatic updates, restart each once, test offline login, open local files without optional storage, connect to one non-home network, and open this guide with all networks disabled.

Owner handoff record

Machine label	
Guide version verified	
Windows boot/update/offline login	
Arch boot/update/offline login	
Non-home Wi-Fi tested	
Optional storage fails soft	
Private help channel recorded offline	
Owner and administrator review date	

Telos. Homelab — Workstation Owner Guide. Revised 20260727.001. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See `LICENSE` and `CREDITS.md` in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.